

EPISODE 19 (SESSION 1)

A Strengthened Heart

PRIMARY TEXT: EXODUS 5–7

In this episode we are reminded of so many names for God, and we notice that this is one of the first stories where God not only answers when He is asked who He is, but He gives Himself a name. God answers Moses. He shows Moses, and Pharaoh, who He is in stark contrast to the empire.

There's powerful imagery in the story of the Exodus that parallels the God of Israel to the gods of Egypt. As Pharaoh's heart is hardened, "strengthened," throughout the Story, many gods of Egypt are "called out," if you will. Whether it be through the need for which the Egyptians prayed to their god (e.g., gods of the Nile and turning the Nile to blood) or the animal represented in the image of the god (e.g., the blood of a slaughtered lamb on the doors and thresholds), the contrasting imagery, just as with their culture's creation and flood narratives, show us through name and deed this God is intimately present, so different from the many gods of the world.

We have so many names for God, which reminds me of the call in the New Testament to be all things to all people. Rather than have multiple gods that rule and reign and you're lucky for them to bless you, God is this intimate entity who is all things—who was and is.

**Our God is
intimately
present, so
different from
the many gods
of the world.**

The "I am who I am" makes a *little* more sense when we are reminded of the lesson of God meeting us where we are in Genesis. In our mistakes and failures. In our joys and successes. And, most definitely, in the mud and pits and backbreaking oppression of the Israelites enslaved in Egypt—God is there.

**He wants us to
take on the
mantle of His
Kingdom—His
dream and
vision—to bless.**

We weren't made in His image in the beginning to then be cast aside, left alone to beg for blessing and belonging. God continually meets His creation where we are—even someone like Pharaoh—because He wants everyone to recognize and believe that we matter to Him. That we are His children, and He wants us to take on the mantle of His Kingdom—His dream and vision—to bless the world.

He wants us to walk with Him in the cool of the day, in the garden. To live as one with His creation, seeking to redeem and restore humanity with Him, not condemn and destroy it.

And just like God meets us where we are, He will use us where we are if we make ourselves available and, bonus, have passion, *chutzpah*, for Him to use.

If only it were as easy as it sounds. That we could just flip a switch in our minds and hearts to forever remember this promise. To wipe away our fears, insecurities, and doubts. We do live in a world with sin; sin still crouches at the door, hoping to engrave Egypt and empire into our lives, making it difficult to tease out the difference between our God and the gods of Egypt—the gods of our current, Western, individualistic culture.

Even though it isn't as simple as that switch, perhaps the most helpful reminders can be found in the names of God. In the titles we declare at the beginning of our prayers and the prayers of those in the Text.

The God who sees us. The God who provides. The God who rests. The God who knows when to say enough. The God who hears our cries. If we flood our hearts and minds with these attributes and names of God, perhaps we'll continue to become more and more like Him, stepping into the role of *bechor*—an image-bearer seeking to live out the family's legacy.

... perhaps the most helpful reminders can be found in the names of God.

PRAYER

*To the God who sees me, and calls me very good.
The God who provides.
To the God who knows when to stop creating—
stop destroying—knowing when to say enough.
To the God who hears our cries and acts.
Thank you
for your breath and life and hope and trust in us.
May we embrace our share of Your inheritance,
the call to be Your message to the world.
Strengthen our hearts—fill our minds and bodies and
souls,
that we may recognize You and Your voice, always.*

*In the name of the God who was and forever is,
Amen*

THE FOUR PILLARS

EPISODE 19

BEMA Discipleship is built on four pillars; a **Four-Pillared Perspective** to help us remember **to elevate the words of God** (not ours) and help us identify the principles that we see recurring in the Story of God's people.

Here are some applications for this episode echoing the ideas of the four pillars:



TEXT

What might be important to meditate over from Exodus 5–7? What Text could you continue to meditate on, memorize, or dig deeper into?



COMMUNITY

In what ways does your community seek to be God's message to the world? How do you, as a community, choose God's Story and put Him and the Kingdom on display?



DISCIPLESHIP

Who in your life would benefit from a mentor-like relationship, showing what it looks like to be God's bechor? A partnership that models peace, rest, reconciliation, and trust. Who have you kept close to challenge and inspire this in you?



WRESTLING

What in this part of the Story is difficult for you? About the hardening of Pharaoh's heart? Moses's calling in the first place? What might you need to study or look more deeply at? Remember—wrestling is good (especially in community).



Are you a music listener?

Listen along to our BEMA Music Playlists on Spotify.

Song suggestions? Send them to bemabesorah@gmail.com.



BEMA SESSION 1



MEDITATION & PRAYER

REFLECTION, APPLICATION & IMPACT

There are three emphases we are always thinking about in terms of application at BEMA. These may be stated explicitly at times, but often we will want you to do the work of finding ways to connect the dots to the things we are learning. Much of this is what makes the work of BEMA distinct as a ministry of Impact Campus Ministries.

CREATING A SPACE SPIRITUAL FORMATION

*What spiritual practices or disciplines might you need to create space for to connect with God? We believe that **if we do our part of creating space for God, He will fill it.** How might the smallest practice make you readily available to be used by God—to restore peace and trust in our communities and around the world as His part of His Kingdom, an image-bearer, His bechor? How have you created a space to hear God speak to you? How might you be ready to respond to what or where He calls you to?*

CONSIDERING CAMPUS YOUNG PEOPLE FOCUS

***We believe young adults are shaping the future of this world,** and they need to be shown by people just like you what it looks like to be a child and image-bearer of God. They are a generation of world-changers, open to Jesus—they just need people to show them and live out what Jesus is really all about. That partnering with God looks like goodness and compassion and peace, not power and control and self-focus. What young adults might you be able to invite into the family, the beit av, of our good God?*

SACRED STATION THEOLOGY OF WORK

*Being a part of God's Kingdom, partnering with Him, trusting in the Story, being a nation of priests—no matter which title you like best, it isn't just for Sunday mornings or Bible study; this is about what we do in our everyday lives. How might we show how our God is different than empire with our actions and words in our 9–5? Does our physical work bring shalom or chaos? Do we create space to put the love of God and His call to love others on display? The way we manage our employees, interact with customers or coworkers, care for our children, or create products should bless others. **You are doing a sacred work—no matter where you are!***